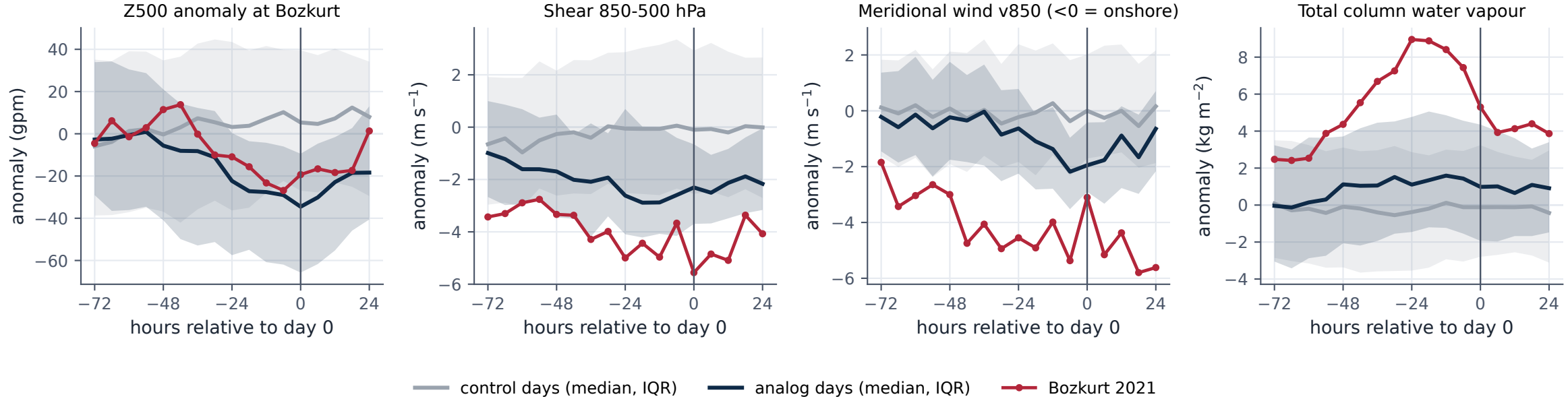How the precursors build up (day-of-year anomalies)